

Fasten Your Seatbelts

Cricket will understand its own priorities in the upheaval caused by the Indian Premier League

■ By Sharda Ugra

The cheer leaders are coming from Washington, the tickets are coming from Prague and the doomsday prophecies are coming from everywhere. The Indian Premier League (IPL), depending on whom you listen to, is going to turn out to be either the Reformation or the Apocalypse. But wishing it away for the sake of defending a mythical past is like trying to stop an incoming tide by flinging pebbles at it.

Like water, muddy or otherwise, the IPL too has found its own level. Amidst a fairly cretinous flexing of financial muscle comes the news that a Caribbean businessman has offered to put up a \$20 million (Rs 80 crore) winner-take-all prize for an England vs West Indies T20 match. Antiguan billionaire Allen Stanford has also hinted that he may throw more loose change into setting up an IPL style domestic T20 league for English cricket. If that happens, the IPL won't be the only big, bad dog on the block which is actually a welcome prospect.

Ask the IPL franchises who have spent the last few months dishing out cash and absorbing punches in the run up to D-day. A very short lead-in time has been compounded by somewhat flexible rules. After all but one team had balanced their budgets at the mega player auction in February, a 'second' afterthought auction was announced and the lone defaulter met its minimum spend on player salaries.

Bangalore Royal Challengers CEO Charu Sharma gently points out that there were two-and-a-half years between the formation of franchises in

the US' Major League Soccer and its first match. IPL teams have had two months. The Hyderabad Deccan Chargers got the floodlight towers at their homeground up and running inside two weeks. They have installed permanent seating and got 58 corporate boxes ready for the single malt schmoozers. The franchises believe they could lose between Rs 15 and Rs 20

set of enemies (though that it can manage effortlessly on its own as well).

If the IPL turns out to be a bit of a damp squib, all that it will lead to are a few plum-coloured faces. But should it be a roaring success then cricket has a real battle on its hands. Overcharged and overworked beavers today, the franchises will turn into bulls, sharks and hawks wanting more. In the valuation game, (which is what all team owners are playing) more IPL will mean higher value. They will demand an expanded calendar for the IPL and will refuse to be refused. Then, the six-week window which ICC refuses to make room for as if it were an illegal tenant, will seem like a demure knock on the door.

In order to deal with the upheaval caused by the IPL, cricket as a whole will need wisdom, sagacity and foresight. The IPL hierarchy is a stranger to those qualities as it only embraces brand value, marketability and an institutional arrogance. In the best-case scenario, all three forms of cricket will survive and the IPL will become the template for successful T20 leagues that bring crowds to domestic games. At the other end of the scale is that apocalypse.

But it is worth understanding that if Test matches are extinct two decades later, it will be because cricket—its governors, its players and its entire community—didn't fight hard enough for them, didn't believe them to be worth preserving. Claiming that "the market demanded it" will be lazy rationalisation.

Cricket will save only what it wants to save.



If the IPL succeeds, the franchises will demand an extended calendar.

crore this year. Now that may be a financial calamity for a few and a handy tax write-off for others but for Mumbai Indians chief Mukesh Ambani, who once bought his wife a corporate jet valued at Rs 242 crore, it is a total sneeze.

With the creation of the IPL, BCCI has broadened the cricket economy, discovered new collaborators and made a new